

to be shooed away. Two-time Major winner Mark O'Meara laughed, "I tried to tune it all out but I guess the same would happen if you played a Tour event in New York City."

The arrival of the European Tour also showed up the strengths and limitations of Indian golf. The sport's development has been skewed with the calibre of the playing pro becoming stronger but its playing base remaining limited. Of India's 180 golf courses, only one, Lado Sarai in New Delhi is a public golf course. The US state of Florida itself has more than 300 public courses. China has taken to golf course development with missionary

Kapur play in Europe and Atwal and Singh having won two European Tour titles each. Fourteen out of 29 Indians made the cut at the Emaar-MGF Indian Masters and four featured in the top 15. The Chinese, on the other hand do well to push more than two through into the money rounds.

An older generation of caddy-pros may have felt inhibited about playing overseas due to cultural constraints, but today a handful, like Masters winner SSP Chowrasia are more at home in Asia. On the road now the distinction between the Indian 'caddy pros' and

STRONG SHOW: Atwal (left) and Dig Vijay Singh had top 15 finishes

through. "It starts this way, by having your players out there winning in Europe. It also helps having an event of this magnitude. But building golf takes time. These are steps in the right direction." Chowrasia's victory could become another landmark in Indian golf's movement westwards but there is much to do on home turf.

Asian Tour boss Han says India needs more golfing facilities for the general public along with to broaden its talent pool and continued corporate support for big events to give playing opportunities to its pros.

More than any Indian sport bar cricket, golf has its finances well-or-



HOME RETURNS

Other than occasional bursts of infighting, more than other sports, Indian golf has figured out how to keep its finances strong. The Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI), established in 2006, is the main touring circuit for Indian golfers. In 2006-07, the PGTI Tour offered Rs 4.6 crore prize money over 10 events and its Order of Merit winner Ashok Kumar made Rs 44.17 lakh in prize money. For the 2007-2008 season, the PGTI tour has Rs 5.65 crore lined up for 13 scheduled rupee prize money events. This year India will stage four Asian Tour events. The country now is second only to China as an Asian Tour tournament host.

Despite a small number of courses, the real wealth of Indian golf lies in its players who are now going overseas in numbers and advertising its quality.

fervour: from its first course in 1984, China now has more than 300. In 2006, China hosted six European Tour events (more than even Scotland) and has four lined up for this year.

India's real wealth though is its players, who compete in numbers on the Asian tour. Jeev Milkha Singh, Arjun Atwal (who also qualified for the US Tour), Jyoti Randhawa and Shiv

the 'gentleman pros', is more diffused. Men from very different backgrounds often share rooms, meals and advice.

After Chowrasia's win, Singh remarked, "People have been talking about a caddie reaching the top... to me, there is nothing called a caddie golfer or a gentleman golfer. They are all the same." O'Meara believes India is doing much right by sending players

organised (see box). Professional Golf Tour of India (PGTI) Commissioner Ajai Gupta now wants a concerted drive for more public courses and to take the Tour to the second tier metros like Jalandhar, Baroda and Patna. The PGTI has plans to develop a 'B' tour to help players from smaller metros.

Gupta remembers the days golf pros would travel by train to venues and play for prize purses of a few lakhs. Every time an Indian golfer like Chowrasia tears up the script of a sport which has for long only included a particular kind of cast, he sits back with satisfaction. This is what Indian golf is all about, he says, "These are the stories we are trying to create." ■